

Session 9

Critical Role and long-form narrative. Unit 3: Practice.

DATE	TIME	LENGTH	ROOM	SECTION
Monday 21 September 2026	10:00 AM to 12:50 PM	170 minutes	SCI L104	18432

BEFORE YOU WALK IN

two things on the calendar sit on top of this class

9:00 AM	USC Games Faculty & Staff, Zoom Gini Benson's weekly. Ends 10:00.	CLASH
9:00 AM	USC Dept call Your own entry, ends 9:50.	
10:00 AM	CTIN 290 Session 9, SCI L104 170 minutes. This document.	NOW
10:00 AM	Gordon / Alex, Google Meet Two hours, straight through class. On the GGP calendar, not this one.	CLASH
2:00 PM	Jeff McClusky, Festival University Introduced by Travis Laurendine. 15 colleges, 8 festivals.	
3:00 PM	Remy Routh Moved from 2:00 when McClusky landed.	

The two collisions, plainly

Gini Benson's faculty meeting ends at 10:00 and class starts at 10:00. You cannot be on Zoom at 9:59 and in SCI L104 at 10:00. Leave the Zoom at 9:45 or accept that Session 9 opens at 10:10, which costs you the opening block.

Gordon / Alex is booked 10:00 to 12:00, straight through the class. It is a recurring hold on the GGP calendar, so it does not show next to CTIN 290 on your main one. Alex is owed a prompt answer, so move it rather than ghost it.

THREE OBJECTIVES, RANKED

if you ran out of time, cut from the bottom

1 Name a visual signature and point at the frames that carry it.

DO NOT CUT

Costume, posture, gesture, and the way those choices persist across hours of performance. This is the exact skill the Visual Analysis video is graded on and it is due Thursday, so if only one thing survives the morning, this is it.

2 Say out loud what a cut costs.

PROTECT IT

In a theater your eye chooses and you can watch the person who is not speaking. On a screen somebody chose for you. Name the gain, close-ups no seat could buy, then name the loss. This is the first appearance of Adaptation, which you name properly in Session 12.

3 Put three terms in their hands: blocking, gesturality, reaction shot.

RECOVERABLE

Each one gets seen on screen before it gets defined. The exit ticket tells you whether they actually landed.

Where the slack actually is

Synthesis runs **59 minutes**, from 11:46 to 12:45. It is by far the longest block and the only one with real give in it. If you are behind after the break, take it out of there, not out of Hamilton. Fifteen minutes of peer sharing still does the work; skipping the second text loses the day's idea.

THE RUN SHEET

wall clock, because elapsed minutes are useless while teaching

10:00 AM Opening

10:12 AM

12 MIN

Introduce Critical Role as long-form visual and narrative practice. 450+ hours of performance. Focus: how do actors establish character visually? Costume, movement, voice.

10:12 AM Character Establishment

10:48 AM

36 MIN

Watch CR opening 30 min. Identify each character's introduction. What visual/physical choices define them? Costume? Posture? Gesture? How do these choices persist?

10:48 AM Activity

11:06 AM

18 MIN

Character Annotation: Students pick one CR character. Describe their visual signature. Costume details. Recurring gestures. Physical habits.

11:06 AM Ten-Minute Break

11:16 AM

10 MIN

The block is 170 minutes now, not 110. One five-minute break was enough for a two-hour class and it is not enough for this one. Take the full ten and leave the room, because the back half is the half that has to land.

11:16 AM Second Text, Hamilton, and the Camera as the Thing You Lost

11:46 AM

30 MIN

Critical Role gives you performance with an unmoving camera and four hours to breathe. Hamilton is a stage show crossed onto a screen, and the trailer is where the cost of that crossing becomes visible. In a theater your eye chooses, and you can watch the person who is not speaking. On a screen somebody chose for you. Ask what that gains, because it does gain something real: close-ups no seat in the house could ever buy. Then ask what it costs. This is the first appearance of the Adaptation through-line you name properly in Session 12, and it lands harder here, straight after an hour of watching performance with no director's eye in the way.

11:46 AM Synthesis

12:45 PM

59 MIN

Peer sharing. What visual choices define characters? How do these persist over long narrative? Discuss: how does long-form differ from film? What narrative techniques appear? Homework: watch 1 hour of CR. Annotate one character's visual arc.

12:45 PM Exit Ticket, Two Lines Before Anyone Leaves

12:50 PM

5 MIN

One term you learned today and where you saw it. One thing you are still unsure of. Collect them at the door. This costs five minutes and it is the cheapest instrument you have for finding out what actually landed. The two things students are least likely to volunteer are which concept went past them and what they believe is expected of them, and this asks for both directly. Read them before the next session and open with the most common confusion, by name, so the room learns that saying you are lost actually changes what happens.

SAY THESE FOUR THINGS OUT LOUD

- **At 10:00.** "Four hundred and fifty hours of performance, one camera that barely moves. By noon you will be able to tell these people apart with the sound off."
- **At 11:16, opening Hamilton.** "In a theater your eye chooses. On a screen somebody chose for you. What did that buy, and what did it cost?"
- **Whenever you name a term.** Show it on screen first, define it second. All three of today's terms are visible before they are words.
- **At 12:45, collecting the exit tickets.** "One term and where you saw it. One thing you are still unsure of. The second line is the one I actually need."

TODAY'S THREE TERMS

seen before defined, one question each

Blocking

DEFINITION

The choreography of character and camera movement within a scene; physical positioning and trajectory.

WHAT TO LOOK AT

Bodies at a table. Who leans in, who pulls back, and when.

WHERE YOU SEE IT

Sample any 10 min

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbynm0pGX0>

ASK THE ROOM

Who moved last, and what did that movement tell you before anybody spoke?

Gesturality

DEFINITION

The expressive quality of movement; how characters move and what that movement communicates about state, intent, or personality.

WHAT TO LOOK AT

One performer, many selves, distinguished almost entirely by how they move.

WHERE YOU SEE IT

Throughout, 2:26

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wxN1T1uxQ2g>

ASK THE ROOM

If you muted this, how many of these people could you still tell apart?

Reaction Shot

DEFINITION

A shot of a character responding to action; often cut in for emotional emphasis or continuity.

WHAT TO LOOK AT

The table's faces are the story as often as the speaker is.

WHERE YOU SEE IT

Sample any 10 min

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbynm0pGX0>

ASK THE ROOM

Whose face is the story right now, and is it the person talking?

MEDIA, IN PLAY ORDER

**DO NOT
OPEN**

Critical Role Campaign 4 (Aramán), Opening Episode

Study character introduction and establishment. Notice costume, blocking, voice, and environment. How do they work together?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uo9z2gIUUmUo> · 1:26 long · First 30 minutes

10:12 AM

Critical Role Campaign 4, Key Character Moments

Official, Critical Role. Examine how performance and visual choices establish personality and relationships over long narrative.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbynm0pGX0> · 4 h 27 m long · Sample any 10 minutes

DO NOT
OPEN

Critical Role Campaign 4, Action Sequences

Study how visual chaos is managed. Cutting, focus, character tracking in ensemble action.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uo9z2gIUuUo> · 1:26 long · Combat moments (variable)

11:16 AM

Hamilton, Official Trailer (Disney+)

Official, Disney. A live stage show shot for a camera, cut from several performances plus a dedicated camera session on a closed stage. That is exactly the problem Critical Role solves every week and the problem your engine camera solves too: where do you put the lens when the performance was not staged for one. Watch blocking, watch where a cut steals your choice of what to look at, and watch how much a reaction shot changes a line you have already heard.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DSCKfXpAGHc> · 1:00 long · Throughout

10:12 AM

Blocking (glossary clip)

Bodies at a table. Who leans in, who pulls back, and when.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbynm0pGX0> · 4 h 27 m long · Sample any 10 min

ON DEMAND

Gesturality (glossary clip)

One performer, many selves, distinguished almost entirely by how they move.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wxN1T1uxQ2g> · 2:42 long · Throughout

10:12 AM

Reaction Shot (glossary clip)

The table's faces are the story as often as the speaker is.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbynm0pGX0> · 4 h 27 m long · Sample any 10 min

The 10:12 block cannot run as written, and this is the one thing to fix before you walk in

"Watch CR opening 30 min" points at a video that is 1 minute 26 seconds long. [Uo9z2gIUuUo](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uo9z2gIUuUo) is a clip called *The Tables Converge*. Open it at 10:12 and you have eighty-six seconds and then thirty-four minutes of nothing in front of twelve people.

Play 3Mbynm0pGX0 instead. That is *The Fall of Thjazi Fang, Campaign 4, Episode 1*, four hours and twenty-seven minutes, the actual episode with the actual character introductions in it. Same official channel. Durations checked twice tonight, two different methods, same answers.

Scrub it before 10:00 and write the number here, because a cold scrub in front of the room is four minutes you do not have: the episode proper starts at _____ and you stop at _____.

Hamilton is sixty seconds and the block is thirty minutes. That is not a problem, it is the shape of the block: play it three times. Cold. Again muted, so they watch only where the cuts land. Then a third time with the room calling each cut out loud. Ninety seconds of tape, twenty-eight minutes of argument.

Two smaller ones. "Action Sequences" is the same 1:26 clip under a different name, so there is no third Critical Role video. And the glossary calls 3Mbynm0pGX0 "Key Character Moments" and says "sample any 10 min" with no timestamp, which is a four and a half hour video; pick your ten minutes tonight, not at the podium.

WHAT IS DUE, AND WHAT IS COMING

- **Thursday 24 September, 5:00 PM PT. Visual Analysis Video, 10%.** One world, two media, three to five minutes. Session 9 is the last Monday before it lands, and today's whole first hour is the skill it is graded on. Say the deadline out loud at 10:00 and again at 12:45.
- **Tonight's homework, from the synthesis block.** Watch one hour of Critical Role. Annotate one character's visual arc.
- **Mood board.** The rubric says the file is due **Thursday 1 October** with presentations Monday 5 October. The grading table in the same guide still says 24 September. **These contradict each other and students will ask.** Say 1 October, which is the corrected date and the one the rubric explains, then get the grading table fixed.

WHAT THEY WERE ASKED TO DO BEFORE TODAY

from the syllabus, so you can ask for it

Sample ten minutes of Critical Role Campaign 4, Episode 1 before class. Rewatch Blocking, Gesturality and Reaction Shot afterwards.

Session 9 collects nothing and issues no graded work. Nothing is due at the door today, so the only thing you are chasing in the room is whether they watched.

ONE SPARE ACTIVITY, IF YOU FINISH EARLY

Sound off, five minutes

Play any ten minutes of 3Mbym0pGX0 with the audio muted. Ask them to write down, without conferring, who is currently the most powerful person at that table and what told them. Then unmute and play the same ten minutes again.

It costs five minutes, it proves gesturality and reaction shot in one move, and it hands them a method they can use on Thursday's assignment tonight.

AFTER CLASS, TWO LINES

write them before you open the laptop

What paid for the extra minutes today?

What is the most common thing on the exit tickets, and how do you open Session 10 with it?

Session text, timing blocks and glossary entries are lifted verbatim from the CTIN 290 Fall 2026 Teacher's Guide, artifact ede331ff. Objectives, the ranking, the wall clock, the spare activity, the four spoken lines and the defect notes are Darby's and are marked as such. Every video verified live against the YouTube oEmbed endpoint on 20 September 2026. Calendar read from gbellamy@gmail.com and ggpcarity@gmail.com the same evening. Built for letter paper.